complaints later and that they should go now. Some of them then spoke up and said that they would only leave if they were given *beedis*. They claimed that I was doing injustice to them. They did not want eggs and milk or fruit but they wanted their *beedis*, which, they said, was like their beloved and that they could not live without them. 'If you do not give it to us then we will all commit suicide.' For the first time I started to sweat. The other three jails had effectively accepted the ban; if I gave these convicts any concessions then everything would be undone. I had to overcome the situation and so I plunged headlong into it. I told them that what was making them behave like this was because of the withdrawal symptoms. What they were undergoing was the *tootan* phase (a period of withdrawal where the body seems to be breaking). At that they all laughed and said, 'Madam knows what is *tootan*.' I said yes, and that I would provide six more doctors so that they could get medical assistance in this difficult period. They would administer a homoeopathic drug called 'tobaccum', I told them, and that would reduce their desire for tobacco. They told me they had stooped to killing lizards and were drying them and eating them to kill their urge. We had a lot of discussion that day about what I should do and what I should not. So ultimately I told them that I would hold discussions with doctors and psychiatrists and only then tell them what had been decided. Till then, I told them, the ban continues. I was desperate to buy time because I was also apprehensive that the situation might go out of control. That would have undone all the good we had managed in the other areas. I was given suggestions by my staff that we should isolate the more vocal of the lot and that would have a restraining effect on the others. I did not agree with this because that would have meant that people would stop speaking out and that would undermine our attempts at bringing about transparency in the jail. Finally, I persuaded them to give me two days' time to [hold] consultations with doctors and then I would let them know my decision. We managed to save the situation and the convicts went back to their barracks.

That night I could not go to sleep as I kept wondering what could be happening in the prison. In the morning I consulted Dr Harinder Sethi (a psychiatrist doing voluntary service with us) and told him the situation. I asked him if he would stand by me in maintaining that the ban was necessary on grounds of health if the prisoners filed an appeal against it in court? He assured me he would and so I asked him to send me his written opinion. The doctor had been working in the Aasra treatment centre and had often complained about the smoking habit of the prisoners and now he was more than willing to help me. Every day one of my superintendents, Tarseem Kumar, would ask me what I had decided in the hope that I would relent a little. Whatever I told him was sure to be spread among the prisoners and so I told him that I was consulting psychiatrists and doctors on the matter. This way I was able to borrow five days. On the sixth day I told them there was no change in policy. But by now matters had quite settled down. On the seventh day I visited the jail. I deliberately did not go to the convict section. Promptly a letter was sent to me through the petition box. It was signed by a number of convicts and they wanted to know if I was still annoyed with them and that they were truly apologetic about their behaviour and would I not forgive them? They knew that I had come to visit the jail but that I did not come to their section. They asked me to visit them and I wrote back that I would do so after a day. I knew then that we had succeeded!

As per the Jail Manual the IG is given a lot of discretionary powers and I was only allowing them privileges that I thought were for their good and withdrawing those that were bad. Today there is a Bill pending in the Delhi Legislative Assembly to ban smoking in public places and so I am certainly not wrong in wanting to remove the smoking clause from the Manual. That would